

June 12th, 2026

INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice Selection Committee

Dear Members of the Selection Committee,

It is my pleasure to write in support of Professor Mohammad Dehghani's nomination for the 2026 INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice.

I currently serve as Global AI and Generative AI Market Strategy Lead at SAS, where I work with organizations worldwide on the adoption of Artificial Intelligence, Generative AI, and Agentic AI technologies. My background includes experience as a data scientist, AI consultant, thought leader and technology strategist, and my work focuses on helping enterprises translate emerging AI capabilities into practical business outcomes.

I had the opportunity to participate as a guest speaker in Professor Dehghani's IE 5374: Applied Generative AI course at Northeastern University, where I delivered a session on Agentic AI and engaged directly with students. Through this experience, I gained firsthand insight into the quality of the course, the preparedness of its students, and Professor Dehghani's effectiveness in bridging academic rigor with real-world practice.

What impressed me most was how successfully the course develops the exact skills that industry is increasingly demanding. We are currently experiencing one of the most significant technological shifts in decades. As Generative AI transforms industries, employers are seeking graduates who can move beyond theoretical understanding and apply AI technologies to solve practical business problems. Professor Dehghani's course addresses this need directly.

The students demonstrated an exceptional ability to connect technical concepts with real-world applications. During my session, they asked thoughtful and sophisticated questions about AI agent architectures, governance, decision-making frameworks, human oversight, and enterprise adoption challenges. Their questions reflected not only technical understanding but also a strong appreciation for the organizational, ethical, and operational considerations that accompany the deployment of AI systems in practice.

I was equally impressed by the student projects presented throughout the course. Rather than focusing solely on theoretical exercises, students developed solutions that addressed meaningful real-world challenges. For example, one team developed PromptBud, a browser-based tool designed to help users optimize prompts directly within their workflow, demonstrating a practical understanding of how Generative AI can improve productivity and user experience. Another team created SerenAI, an LLM-powered application for wearable devices that provides mental health insights and personalized recommendations, illustrating the students' ability to combine emerging AI technologies with socially impactful applications.

These projects were notable not only for their technical execution but also for the entrepreneurial thinking, problem framing, and user-centered design principles they embodied. Importantly, students had the opportunity to present their capstone projects at Google, providing them with

valuable exposure to industry professionals and reinforcing the applied, practice-oriented nature of the course.

From an industry perspective, Professor Dehghani's course is particularly significant because it was among the early academic offerings dedicated to Applied Generative AI within our field. At a time when organizations are rapidly adapting to AI-driven transformation, this course equips students with practical experience that directly translates into workforce readiness. I understand that many students have already leveraged the skills developed through this course to secure co-op positions, internships, and full-time employment opportunities, which is a strong indicator of its relevance and impact.

I would also like to highlight another aspect of the course that I found particularly encouraging: the strong participation of women. As someone who is deeply committed to expanding opportunities for women in AI and technology, it was inspiring to see a significant representation of female students actively engaging with advanced AI concepts, building innovative solutions, and demonstrating leadership within their teams. Courses like this play an important role in helping develop a more diverse and inclusive future workforce in AI.

In my role, I regularly engage with hundreds of organizations globally on AI adoption and speak at industry conferences, universities, and executive forums. Few academic programs I have encountered demonstrate this level of alignment between emerging AI technologies and workforce needs.

The INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice recognizes educators who help students acquire the knowledge and skills necessary to become effective practitioners. Based on my firsthand experience, Professor Dehghani exemplifies this mission. He has created a learning environment that combines academic excellence, technical innovation, industry relevance, and practical application in a way that prepares students to contribute immediately and meaningfully in a rapidly evolving profession.

For these reasons, I offer my strongest endorsement of Professor Mohammad Dehghani for the 2026 INFORMS Prize for the Teaching of OR/MS Practice.

Sincerely,

Marinela Profi
Global AI & Generative AI Market Strategy Lead
SAS

Email: info@marinelaprofi.com

Website: marinelaprofi.com